MEASURED ON CLAUDE CODE TRANSCRIPTS

Ten subagents, 3% of payload

Fan-out almost never buys you speed

SUBAGENT COLD START

37k

tokens per spawn

only 950 of them are the actual task — that is 3%

WHERE THE OTHER 97% GOES

- system prompt and tool schemas
- project rules and environment
- 80% of it rewritten each spawn
- 53% of spawns miss a warm cache

THE PREAMBLE NEVER AMORTIZES

~25%

of the bill, any length

30% at five turns, 20% at eighty — it is re-read on every turn

ANTHROPIC MOVED ITS OWN NUMBER

- then: 15x tokens for +90.2%
- now: 3-10x over a single agent
- plus a blunt start with the simplest
- split on context, not on plan items

MORE

Fan-out does not buy time, it buys a quiet context

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